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IPL 2026: Overlooked Shubman Gill, Shreyas Iyer eye redemption in GT-PBKS opener

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Synopsis

Overlooked on the international T20 stage, Shubman Gill and Shreyas Iyer headline IPL 2026's opening clash in Mullanpur, each with a point to prove as captains of Gujarat Titans and Punjab Kings. Gill, despite prolific IPL returns, remains under scrutiny for his strike rate and place in India's T20 setup, while Iyer continues to be ignored at the national level despite elite IPL leadership and a high-impact 2025 season. Punjab, meanwhile, bank on Iyer's leadership and an explosive Indian batting core, though questions linger over the form of their opening pair and their inconsistent home record.



Indian batters Shubman Gill and Shreyas Iyer run between wickets during the second ODI cricket match between India and Australia

Mullanpur: [Shubman Gill](#) and [Shreyas Iyer](#), two India T20I batters who have often been overlooked, will captain [Gujarat Titans](#) and [Punjab Kings](#) respectively, each eager to make a statement in a high-stakes [Indian Premier League](#) opener here on Tuesday.

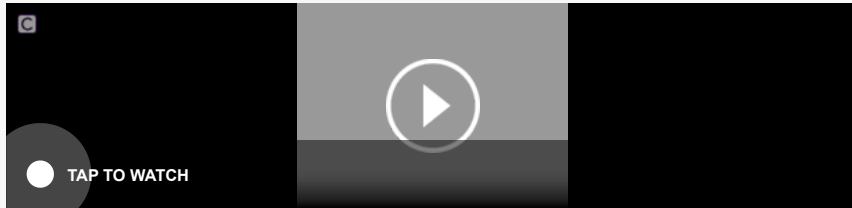
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India's Test and ODI captain Gill, who was named T20I vice-captain but later left out of the World Cup squad to accommodate Sanju Samson, has a lot to answer in the shortest format.

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While India went on to win a record third ICC T20 World Cup, Gill enters this season at a crucial phase in his T20 career.

Since 2023, only Virat Kohli has scored more IPL runs than Gill, but the focus has shifted from consistency to strike rate. With a career T20 strike rate of around 138, Gill showed signs of improvement last season, scoring at over 155-something he would look to build on.

With Matthew Hayden now part of the coaching staff as batting coach, Gill's six-hitting and intent at the top will be closely watched.

Since Hardik Pandya's exit after IPL 2023, Gill has grown into his leadership role, and the team now clearly revolves around him.

Having won the title in their debut season in 2022, Gujarat Titans have remained one of the most consistent sides, finishing third last year before losing to Mumbai Indians in the Eliminator.

Also Read: [Rohit Sharma and Ryan Rickelton's blistering fifties power Mumbai Indians to 6-wicket win over KKR in IPL](#)

They look one of the most settled units again, retaining 20 players. The opening pair of Gill and Sai Sudharsan -- last season's top scorer with 759 runs -- remains their biggest strength.

Sudharsan is returning after a rib fracture but was in fine touch in domestic

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cricket, including an unbeaten 101 and multiple fifties before the injury.

GT also have exciting backup options like wicketkeeper-batter Kumar Kushagra, who impressed in domestic cricket with a strike rate of over 160 and an average above 60 in the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy. He would offer flexibility if the middle order struggles.

For Punjab Kings, much will again depend on skipper Shreyas, a proven IPL leader who has now taken three different teams to the final (Delhi Capitals in 2020, KKR in their 2024 triumph and PBKS last season).

Despite his consistent performances, Shreyas continues to be overlooked by the Ajit Agarkar-led selection committee, having last played a T20I in December 2023.

The skipper also led from the front last season, scoring 604 runs at a strike rate of over 175, which was the highest among the top-10 run-getters.

Yet, he failed to break into India's T20I XI in the Asia Cup and the T20 World Cup, even after being called up as a replacement for Tilak Varma during the build-up home series against New Zealand ahead of the global showpiece.

Punjab's strength lies in their explosive Indian core.

Openers Prabhsimran Singh and Priyansh Arya were among the most destructive pairs last season, scoring 1,024 runs together at a strike rate of nearly 169.

However, both have had a relatively quiet Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy, raising questions about their current form.

The middle order, featuring Nehal Wadhera, Shashank Singh and Suryansh Shedge, will be crucial, especially against a strong spin attack led by Rashid Khan.

PBKS will also have a new No. 3 in Australia's Cooper Connolly as a replacement for Josh Inglis, who was released ahead of [IPL 2026](#) due to availability issues.

Connolly is expected to play as a specialist batter initially, as Cricket Australia has advised him to avoid bowling while recovering from a back problem.

Punjab will also be keen to improve their home record as, despite reaching the final last season, they had only two wins in five matches in New Chandigarh last year.

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Punjab Kings: Shreyas Iyer (c), Nehal Wadhera, Vishnu Vinod, Harnoor Pannu, Pyla Avinash, Prabhsimran Singh, Shashank Singh, Marcus Stoinis, Harprett Brar, Marco Jansen, Azmatullah Omarzai, Priyansh Arya, Musheer Khan, Suryansh Shedge, Mitch Owen, Cooper Connolly, Ben Dwarshuis, Arshdeep Singh, Yuzvendra Chahal, Vyshak Vijaykumar, Yash Thakur, Xavier Bartlett, Pravin Dubey and Vishal Nishad.

Gujarat Titans: Shubman Gill (c), Sai Sudharsan, Jos Buttler, Kumar Kushagra, Anuj Rawat, Tom Banton, Glenn Phillips, Nishant Sindhu, Washington Sundar, Mohammed Arshad Khan, Sai Kishore, Jayant Yadav, Jason Holder, Rahul Tewatia, Shahrukh Khan, Kagiso Rabada, Mohammed Siraj, Prasidh Krishna, Manav Suthar, Gurnoor Singh Brar, Ishant Sharma, Ashok Sharma, Luke Wood, Kulwant hejroliya and Rashid Khan.

Match starts: 7.30pm.

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